

Hunger

It was hard to believe the flesh was heavy on my back.

The fisherman said: will you have her, carelessly,
trailing his nets and his nerves, as though his words
sanctified the purpose with which he faced himself.

I saw his white bone thrash his eyes.

I followed him across the sprawling sands, my
mind thumping in the flesh's sling.
Hope lay perhaps in burning the house I lived in.
Silence gripped my sleeves; his body clawed
at the froth his old nets had dragged up from the seas.

In the flickering dark his lean-to opened like a wound.
The wind was I, and the days and nights before.
Palm fronds scratched my skin. Inside the shack
an oil lamp splayed the hours bunched to the walls.

Over and over the sticky soot crossed the space of my mind
I heard him say: my daughter, she's just turned fifteen ...
Feel her. I'll be back soon, your bus leaves at nine.
The sky fell on me, and a father's exhausted wile.
Long and lean, her years were cold as rubber.
She opened her wormy legs wide. I felt the hunger there,
the other one, the fish slithering, turning inside.

--Jayant Mahapatra

About the Poem: Hunger

- **Genre:** Social realist / Confessional / Indian English poetry
- **Published:** Poetry Collection *A Rain of Rites* (1976)
- **Theme:** Poverty, exploitation, moral degradation, physical and emotional hunger
- **Setting:** Coastal fishing village in India
- **Style:** Stark realism, disturbing imagery, symbolic use of sea and flesh, first-person narration
- **Tone:** Dark, tragic, unsettling, morally intense
- **Central Idea:** Hunger is not only physical but also moral and social; extreme poverty forces people into inhuman choices

About the Poet: Jayant Mahapatra (1928–2023)

- **Nationality:** Indian
- **Language:** English
- **Known as:** One of the major voices of Indian English poetry
- **Famous for:** Poems like "*Hunger*," "*Indian Summer*," "*Dawn at Puri*"
- **Style:** Introspective, symbolic, deeply rooted in Indian reality, explores guilt, faith, suffering, and social injustice
- **Background:** Born in Odisha; originally a professor of physics before turning to poetry
- **Awards:** Sahitya Akademi Award (1979), Padma Shri (2009)

Meaning of the Poem

The poem "*Hunger*" by Jayant Mahapatra presents a **grim and disturbing** picture of **poverty, exploitation, and human suffering**. It shows how **extreme hunger** forces a poor fisherman to offer his **young daughter** to a stranger in order to survive. The speaker, though **morally disturbed** and emotionally shaken, becomes a **silent participant** in this act. Through **powerful and shocking imagery**, the poem reveals that hunger is not only **physical** but also **moral and social**, leading to the **loss of human dignity and values**. Overall, the poem exposes the **harsh realities of poverty** and strongly **criticizes a society** where desperation results in **inhuman actions**.

The Right Image

The right image is a lake

Under my heart.

Not one swan but a flock,

all black, is cutting

the reflection

of a moon that is not there.

-- Agha Shahid Ali

About the Poem: "The Right Image"

- **Genre:** Symbolic / Reflective / Indian English poetry
- **Theme:** Identity, imagination, inner self, illusion vs reality
- **Style:** Brief, imagistic, metaphorical, modern
- **Tone:** Quiet, introspective, slightly mysterious
- **Central Idea:** The poem explores how a person's **true image** exists within the **inner emotional world**, not external reality.

About the Poet: Agha Shahid Ali (1949–2001)

- **Nationality:** Indian-American
- **Language:** English
- **Known for:** Lyric poetry, imagery, themes of exile, memory, loss, and identity
- **Famous works:** "Postcard from Kashmir," "The Country Without a Post Office"
- **Style:** Rich imagery, symbolism, emotional depth, modern sensibility
- **Background:** Born in Kashmir, later lived and taught in the United States

Meaning of the Poem

In "The Right Image," Agha Shahid Ali presents a **symbolic picture** of the poet's **inner self**. The *lake under the heart* represents the **deep emotional world** within him. The **black swans** suggest **dark, complex thoughts or hidden emotions**, while the **moon that is not there** symbolizes an **illusion or imagined ideal**. The cutting of the reflection shows how **inner conflicts disturb self-perception**. Overall, the poem suggests that a person's **true identity** is shaped by **inner feelings and imagination**, not by what is visibly real.

Sunrise

A sort of war was on between the clouds and
the sky.

The one was raining heavily, the other was
lightening, and it was
thundering between them.

The sun rose late from the thick layer of cloud,
semi-pale and
shaky yellow, like an arrogant school boy who
has been late
for his class.

"I am here now. Let the class start," he seems
to be boasting to
the clouds, still threatening in their rain.

But he tiptoed and sat in the corner of the last
bench, afraid of the
stern and angry stare of the sky.

The sky was writing on the blackboard that
the sun's colour had
changed, his slate was dirty, he had not eaten anything, and the
sun was trembling more and more.

Who has given the school master so much
wisdom to punish
the late-comers without knowing their real
reasons? The sun is whispering to the clouds that there
is no wisdom
in under estimating the gleams of the sun, and
there is no fixed time for the sun to rise.

-- Padma Sachdev

About the Poem: "Sunrise"

- **Genre:** Symbolic / Reflective / Indian English poetry
- **Theme:** Nature, authority, freedom, individuality, time
- **Style:** Personification, extended metaphor, simple language
- **Tone:** Thoughtful, mildly satirical, philosophical
- **Central Idea:** The poem compares nature to a school, questioning rigid rules and blind authority.

About the Poet: Padma Sachdev (1940–2021)

- **Nationality:** Indian
- **Language:** English and Dogri
- **Known for:** Introducing Dogri literature to the modern literary world
- **Famous for:** Poems and writings on nature, human emotions, and social themes
- **Style:** Simple expression, symbolism, reflective tone
- **Awards:** Sahitya Akademi Award (1971)

Meaning of the Poem

In the poem "*Sunrise*," Padma Sachdev uses **personification** to describe a conflict between the **sun**, **clouds**, and the **sky**. The sun is compared to a **late schoolboy**, while the sky acts as a **strict schoolmaster**. The poem highlights how **authority punishes without understanding reasons**, just as the sky judges the sun unfairly. Through this metaphor, the poet questions **rigid rules** and emphasizes that **nature follows no fixed timetable**. Overall, the poem conveys that **freedom and natural rhythm** should not be judged by **man-made rules**.

The House of My Childhood

The house of my childhood stood empty
On a grey hill
All its furniture gone
Except my grandmother's grindstone
And the brass figurines of her gods
After the death of all birds
Bird-cries still fill the mind
After the city's erasure
A blur still peoples the air
In the colourless crack that comes before morning
In a place where nobody can sing
Words distribute their silence
Among intricately clustered glyphs
My grandmother's voice shivers on a bare branch
I toddle around the empty house
Spring and summer are both gone
Leaving an elderly infant
To explore the rooms of age

-- Dilip Chitre

About the Poem: "The House of My Childhood"

- **Genre:** Reflective / Nostalgic / Indian English poetry
- **Theme:** Memory, loss, childhood, time, silence
- **Style:** Symbolic, imagistic, free verse
- **Tone:** Melancholic, introspective, quiet
- **Central Idea:** The poem explores how **memories of childhood** remain alive even after **physical loss and emptiness**.

About the Poet: Dilip Chitre (1938–2009)

- **Nationality:** Indian
- **Language:** English and Marathi
- **Known for:** Modern Indian poetry, **translation**, and literary criticism
- **Famous for:** Poems reflecting **memory, identity, and urban life**
- **Style:** Deep **imagery**, symbolism, reflective and philosophical tone
- **Background:** Born in Baroda, later lived in Mumbai; an important figure in modern Indian literature

Meaning of the Poem

In *"The House of My Childhood,"* Dilip Chitre recalls an **abandoned childhood home**, symbolizing **loss and the passage of time**. Though the house is empty, **memories remain alive**, especially through the presence of the **grandmother's belongings and voice**. Images like **bird-cries, silence, and empty rooms** suggest emotional emptiness and nostalgia. The poet presents himself as an **"elderly infant,"** showing how aging brings one back to childhood memories. Overall, the poem highlights that while **places and people disappear, memories and emotions continue to exist**.

The Nation

The People are living beings. They have their distinct personalities. But nations are organisations of power, and therefore their inner aspects and outward expressions are everywhere monotonously the same. Their differences are merely differences in the degree of efficiency.

In the modern world, the fight is going on between the living spirit of the people and the methods of nation-organizing. It is like the struggle that began in Central Asia between cultivated areas of man's habitation and the continually encroaching desert sands till the human region of life and beauty was choked out of existence. When the spread of higher ideals of humanity is not held to be important, the hardening method of national efficiency gains a certain strength; and for some limited period of time, at least, it proudly asserts itself as the fittest to survive. But it is the survival of that part of man which is the least living. And this is the reason why dead monotony is a sign of the spread of the Nation. The modern towns, which present the physiognomy due to this dominance of the Nation, are everywhere the same, from San Francisco to London, from London to Tokyo. They show no faces but merely masks.

The People, being living personalities, must have their self-expression, and this leads to their distinctive creations. These creations are literature, art, social symbols and ceremonials. They are like different dishes at one common feast. They add richness to our enjoyment and understanding of truth. They are making the world of man fertile of life and variedly beautiful. But the nations do not create, they merely produce and destroy. Organisations for production are necessary. Even organisations for destruction may be so. But when actuated by greed and hatred, they crowd away into a corner the living man who creates, then the harmony is lost, and the people's history runs at a break-neck speed towards some fatal catastrophe.

Humanity, where it is living, is guided by inner ideals; but where it is a dead organisation, it becomes impervious to them. Its building process is only an external process, and in its response to the moral guidance it has to pass through obstacles that are gross and non-plastic.

Man as a person has his individuality, which is the field where his spirit has its freedom to express itself and to grow. The professional man carries a rigid crust around him which has very little variation and hardly any elasticity. This professionalism is the region where men specialise their knowledge and organise their power, mercilessly elbowing each other in their struggle to come to the front. Professionalism is necessary, without doubt; but it must not be allowed to exceed its healthy limits, to assume complete mastery over the personal man, making him narrow and hard, exclusively intent upon the pursuit of success at the cost of his faith in ideals.

In ancient India, professions were kept within limits by social regulation. They were considered primarily as social necessities and in second place as the means of livelihood for individuals. Thus man, being free from the constant urging of unbounded competition, could have the leisure to cultivate his nature in its completeness.

The Cult of the Nation is the professionalism of the people. This cult is becoming their greatest danger because it is bringing them enormous success, making them impatient of the claims of higher ideals. The greater the amount of success, the stronger the conflicts of interest and jealousy and hatred which are aroused in men's minds, thereby making it more and more necessary for other peoples, who are still living, to stiffen into nations. With the growth of nationalism, man has become the greatest menace to man. Therefore, the continual presence of panic goads that very nationalism into ever-increasing menace.

Crowd psychology is a blind force. Like steam and other physical forces, it can be utilised for creating a tremendous amount of power. And therefore, rulers of men, who, out of greed and fear, are bent upon turning their peoples into machines of power, try to train this crowd psychology for their special purposes. They hold it to be their duty to foster in the popular mind universal panic, unreasoning pride in their own race, and hatred of others. Newspapers, school books, and even religious services are made use of for this object; and those who have the courage to express their disapprobation of this blind and impious cult are either punished in the law courts or are socially ostracised. The individual thinks, even when he feels; but the same individual, when he feels with the crowd, does not reason at all. His moral sense becomes blurred. This suppression of higher humanity in crowd minds is productive of enormous strength. For the crowd mind is essentially primitive; its forces are elemental. Therefore, the Nation is forever watching to take advantage of this enormous power of darkness.

The people's instinct of self-preservation has been made dominant at particular times of crisis. Then, for the time being, the consciousness of its solidarity becomes aggressively wide awake. But in the Nation, this hyperconsciousness is kept alive for all time by artificial means. A man has to act the part of a policeman when he finds his house invaded by burglars. But if that remains his normal condition, then his consciousness of his household becomes acute and over wrought, making him fly at every stranger passing near his house. This intensity of self consciousness is nothing of which a man should feel proud; certainly, it is not healthful. In like manner, incessant self-consciousness in a nation is highly injurious for the people. It serves its immediate purpose but at the cost of the eternal in man.

When a whole body of men train themselves for a particular narrow purpose, it becomes a common interest with them to keep up that purpose and preach absolute loyalty to it. Nationalism is the training of a whole people for a narrow ideal; when it gets hold of their minds, it is sure to lead them to moral degeneracy and intellectual blindness. We cannot but hold firm the faith that this Age of Nationalism, of gigantic vanity and selfishness, is only a passing phase in civilisation, and those who are making permanent arrangements for accommodating this temporary mood of history will be unable to fit themselves for the coming age when the true spirit of freedom will have sway.

With the unchecked growth of Nationalism, the moral foundation of man's civilisation is unconsciously undergoing a change. The idea of the social man is unselfishness, but the idea of the Nation, like that of the professional man, is selfishness. This is why selfishness in the individual is condemned, while in the nation, it is extolled, which leads to hopeless moral blindness, confusing the religion of the people with the religion of the nation. Therefore, to take an example, we find men more and more convinced of the superior claims of Christianity merely because Christian nations are in possession of the greater part of the world. It is like supporting a robber's religion by quoting the amount of his stolen property. Nations celebrate their successful massacre of men in their churches. They forget that Thugs also ascribed their success in manslaughter to the favour of their goddess. But in the case of the latter, their goddess frankly represented the principle of destruction. It was the criminal tribe's own murderous instinct deified—the instinct, not of one individual, but of the whole community, and therefore held sacred. In the same manner, in modern churches, selfishness, hatred and vanity in their collective aspect of national instincts do not scruple to share the homage paid to God.

Of course, the pursuit of self-interest need not be wholly selfish; it can even be in harmony with the interest of all. Therefore, ideally speaking, nationalism, which stands for the expression of the collective self-interest of a people, need not be ashamed of itself if it maintains its true limitations. But what we see in practice is that every nation which has prospered has done so through its career of aggressive selfishness, either in commercial adventures or in foreign possessions, or in both. And this material prosperity not only feeds continually the selfish instincts of the people but impresses men's minds with the lesson that, for a nation, selfishness is a necessity and, therefore, a virtue. It is the

emphasis laid in Europe upon the idea of the Nation's constant increase of power, which is becoming the greatest danger to man, both in its direct activity and its power of infection.

We must admit that evils there are in human nature, in spite of our faith in moral laws and our training in self-control. But they carry on their foreheads their own brand of infamy, their very success adding to their monstrosity. All through man's history, there will be some who suffer and others who cause suffering. The conquest of evil will never be a fully accomplished fact but a continuous process like the process of burning in a flame.

In former ages, when some particular people became turbulent and tried to rob others of their human rights, they sometimes achieved success and sometimes failed. And it amounted to nothing more than that. But when this idea of the Nation, which has met with universal acceptance in the present day, tries to pass off the cult of collective selfishness as a moral duty, simply because that selfishness is gigantic in stature, it not only commits depredation but attacks the very vitals of humanity. It unconsciously generates in people's minds an attitude of defiance against the moral law. For men are taught by repeated devices the lesson that the Nation is greater than the people, while yet it scatters to the winds the moral law that the people have held sacred.

It has been said that a disease becomes most acutely critical when the brain is affected. For it is the brain that is constantly directing the siege against all disease forces. The spirit of national selfishness is that brain disease of a people which shows itself in red eyes and clenched fists, in the violence of talk and movements, all the while shattering its natural restorative powers. But the power of self-sacrifice, together with the moral faculty of sympathy and cooperation, is the guiding spirit of social vitality. Its function is to maintain a beneficent relation of harmony with its surroundings. But when it begins to ignore the moral law which is universal and uses it only within the bounds of its own narrow sphere, then its strength becomes like the strength of madness, which ends in self-destruction.

What is worse, this aberration of a people, decked with the showy title of 'patriotism', proudly walks abroad, passing itself off as a highly moral influence. Thus, it has spread its inflammatory contagion all over the world, proclaiming its fever flush to be the best sign of health. It is causing in the hearts of people, naturally inoffensive, a feeling of envy at not having their temperature as high as that of their delirious neighbours and not being able to cause as much mischief but merely having to suffer from it.

I have often been asked by my Western friends how to cope with this evil, which has attained such sinister strength and vast dimensions. In fact, I have often been blamed for merely giving a warning and offering no alternative. When we suffer as a result of a particular system, we believe that some other system would bring us better luck. We are apt to forget that all systems produce evil sooner or later when the psychology which is at the root of them is wrong. The system which is national today may assume the shape of the international tomorrow; but so long as men have not forsaken their idolatry of primitive instincts and collective passions, the new system will only become a new instrument of suffering. And because we are trained to confound efficient systems with moral goodness itself, every ruined system makes us more and more distrustful of moral law.

Therefore, I do not put my faith in any new institution but in the individuals all over the world who think clearly, feel noble, and act rightly, thus becoming the channels of moral truth. Our moral ideals do not work with chisels and hammers. Like trees, they spread their roots in the soil and their branches in the sky without consulting any architect for their plans.

--Rabindranath Tagore

About the Lesson

- **Genre:** Philosophical Essay / Reflective Prose / Indian English Prose
- **Published:** From lectures later included in *Nationalism* (1917)
- **Style:** Analytical, argumentative, metaphorical
- **Tone:** Serious, critical, warning, philosophical
- **Theme:** **Criticism of nationalism**, conflict between **humanity and organised power**, moral responsibility

About the Author: Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941)

- **Nationality:** Indian
- **Language:** English, Bengali
- **Profession:** Poet, philosopher, essayist, educationist
- **Known for:** Universal humanism, criticism of blind nationalism
- **Famous Works:** *Gitanjali*, *Nationalism*, *The Home and the World*
- **Awards:** Nobel Prize in Literature (1913)
- **Contribution:** First Asian Nobel laureate; global voice of **human values and freedom**

Summary / Central Idea

In the essay *"The Nation"*, Rabindranath Tagore strongly criticizes **nationalism**, which he describes as an **organisation of power**, not a living human entity. He distinguishes between **people**, who are living beings with creativity and moral sense, and the **nation**, which is mechanical, aggressive, and uniform.

Tagore argues that nationalism suppresses **individual freedom**, **moral law**, and **human creativity** in the name of efficiency, power, and success. It encourages **collective selfishness**, jealousy, hatred, and blind loyalty, often glorified as patriotism. Through vivid metaphors—such as **crowd psychology**, **machines of power**, and **disease of the brain**—he shows how nationalism leads to **moral blindness and violence**.

He warns that when nations worship power and success, they sacrifice **humanity**, **sympathy**, and **ethical values**, pushing civilisation towards destruction. Tagore believes that no system—national or international—can save humanity unless individuals themselves uphold **moral truth**, **compassion**, and **universal human ideals**.

Message of the Lesson

- **Humanity is greater than nationalism**
- Blind patriotism leads to **moral decay**
- Power without ethics becomes **destructive**
- True civilisation is built on **sympathy, cooperation, and moral law**
- Real change comes from **individual moral awakening**, not systems

Unity of Mind

My dear citizens of India,

On the eve of the 55th anniversary of our Independence, I have great pleasure in offering you my best wishes for your well-being and happiness. My salutations to all of you, both in India and abroad.

May I extend a special word of gratitude to the men of our defence who guard our frontiers on the land, on the sea and in the air and paramilitary forces. May I also convey my special appreciation to our farmers, who toil on the fields, technicians who keep the wheels of our industry moving, teachers who create knowledge products to the society and doctors, engineers, scientists, technologists and other professionals and administrators who are the prime movers of national development. May I wish the youth of India whose purposeful hard work with sweat will be a major transforming force for prosperous India.

I met some of the freedom fighters a few days ago at the Rashtrapati Bhavan. Each and every one of them was the live force for our freedom movement. On this day, I salute all men and women of India who fought for our freedom and sacrificed their lives to achieve our Independence. Seeding a great vision and an indomitable spirit to achieve India's freedom took place around 1857. For 90 years, there were a number of intensive struggles for freedom. Many of our people and leaders were in jail and their sufferings got transformed into freedom movement, with national ethos under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi. I have tried to capture the essence of the freedom movement. Two aspects have come out: as a result of supreme sacrifices and dedicated and focused efforts, we got our Independence. The second aspect is that the vision driven movement itself created many leaders in different spheres of politics, economics, industry, science, arts and culture.

After Independence, India has made significant achievements in agriculture and food production, energy, healthcare, education and various fields of science and technology. Particularly we have made our mark in the international arena in the fields of pharmaceuticals, information technology, mass media and communication, space, defence and nuclear science.

Similar to the first vision, which created a movement to achieve freedom with unity of minds of our people and the unity of purpose in actions, we need a second vision, which will integrate people from all walks of our society towards a common purpose. The second vision of our nation is to transform it from the present developing status to a developed nation by integrated actions simultaneously in the areas of agriculture and food processing, education and healthcare, infrastructure development including power, information and communication technologies, and critical technologies. This greater vision will aim to alleviate poverty, illiteracy and unemployment. When the minds of the people of our country are unified and fused towards this vision, the dormant potential will manifest as a mammoth power leading to a happy and prosperous life of a billion people. This vision of the nation will also remove the conflicts arising out of differences and small thinking.

Dear citizens, I would like to reiterate that Jammu and Kashmir is an integral part of India. It is not an international issue. India is ready for bilateral dialogue once the cross border terrorism is brought to a complete end. Normal election process is on in Jammu and Kashmir. It is essential to ensure its successful completion and dawn of peace in Jammu and Kashmir.

We also have many challenges in front of us. We have to find a solution to the repeated droughts and floods; we have to eradicate communal and other divisive clashes sprouting in certain parts and remove the pains of our people whether it is in Jammu and Kashmir or in any other part of our country; we also have to find a permanent solution to combat terrorism.

Let us now look at a long-term problem. It is paradoxical to see floods in one part of our country while some other parts face drought. This drought – flood phenomenon is a recurring feature. The need of the hour is to have a water mission, which will enable availability of water to the fields, villages, towns and industries throughout the year, even while maintaining environmental purity. One major part of the water mission would be networking of our rivers. Technological and project management capabilities of our country can rise to the occasion and make this river networking a reality with long term planning and proper investment. In addition, the vast sea around us can help by providing potable water through desalination as a cost-effective technology. There are of course short-term techniques such as water harvesting by revitalizing rural ponds, water recycling to water conservation. Such programmes should have a large-scale people participation even at the conceptual and project planning stages. The entire programme should revolve around economic viability leading to continued prosperity for our people with larger employment potential, environmental sustainability, grass root level motivation and benefit sharing.

I would now like to share with you friends, another crucial requirement and necessity for our country. We cannot sustain a second vision for the country without Unity of Minds of all our people. Our great strength is our pluralistic tradition and civilisational heritage of nearly 3000 years. I have always been asking myself what the strength of our heritage is. A unique fusion has taken place with multiple cultures, religions and the way of life of many parts of the world and that has become the foundation of the Indian life. One can trace from 1857 to date, the type of good experiences we have had and also the strife resulting out of the differences in thoughts.

I have just now returned from Gujarat after interactions with various cross sections of people, leaders, officials and rehabilitation workers in the areas affected by recent disturbances and earthquake. I also visited the Sabarmati Ashram, which was established by Mahatma Gandhi for the purpose of our countrymen to carry on the search for truth and develop fearlessness. I sat in silence for a while in the Ashram and remembered the life of Gandhiji. One dominant thought came to my mind. If we can go above our own personal hardships and see the problems of others and decide to work for a larger cause, then there is natural elevation of our minds. When we are lax in this, then our level of thinking goes down. I felt confident that all of us can be elevated to the level of noble minds, if we just decide to understand others and to practice tolerance. I realized that Gujarat has given the noble leader - Mahatma Gandhi, unifier of the nation – Vallabhbhai Patel and the great visionary in science and technology - Vikram Sarabhai and many more. Time has come for every one of us to put the thoughts of these great souls into action for nation's welfare.

Non-violence, tolerance, acceptance of all religions and different ways of life, search for truth and fearlessness are the values the Mahatma taught us and they are the cornerstones of our civilisational heritage and, therefore, of Indian polity. Any act by anyone anywhere in India that runs counter to these eternal values would pose a threat to the fabric of free Indian nation, which was born and nurtured by the supreme sacrifices of countless noble souls. We should all work together to achieve the mission for Unity of Minds to preserve what we so preciously earned and reach greater heights in the future.

When I interact with school children and youth, wherever I go, one question comes often. They ask me "who are our role models?" Parents and teachers have to show them by example to live as enlightened citizens. Children also look

for role models at national level in different fields. I have described earlier the role models from Gujarat. Each state of our country has many such examples of the past. It is now time we create more role models from the present. I suggest that members of our Parliament and Legislatures can shape the future of our children by becoming good role models. Parliament and Legislatures have a crucial role in giving the vision of developed India and value-based polity. Our children should see the members of the Parliament debating the vision of developed India, providing action plans and putting forth great thoughts and challenges to them. Looking at the national leaders, the children will find their role models for their development and growth.

I am sure, our leadership and our people can achieve the second vision of developed India. Let us take a vow on this Independence Day that the nation is more important compared to any individual, party or organisation.

I pray to the Almighty for Unity of Minds and our success in every aspect of life.

Jai Hind.

-- A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

About the Lesson

- **Genre:** Inspirational Speech / Reflective Prose / Indian English Prose
- **Occasion:** 55th Independence Day Address of India
- **Style:** Simple, motivational, inclusive, visionary
- **Tone:** Patriotic, hopeful, thoughtful, inspirational
- **Theme:** **National unity**, shared vision, moral values, collective responsibility

About the Author: A.P.J. Abdul Kalam (1931–2015)

- **Full Name:** Avul Pakir Jainulabdeen Abdul Kalam
- **Nationality:** Indian
- **Profession:** Scientist, aerospace engineer, educationist, statesman
- **Known as:** *Missile Man of India, People's President*
- **Language:** English
- **Major Contributions:** Space science, defence technology, national development vision
- **Awards:** Bharat Ratna, Padma Bhushan, Padma Vibhushan

Summary / Central Idea

In *"Unity of Mind,"* Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam emphasizes the importance of **national unity** and a **shared vision** for India's future. He begins by paying tribute to freedom fighters, soldiers, farmers, teachers, scientists, and youth who contribute to the nation's strength.

He recalls India's freedom struggle, highlighting how **unity of purpose** and **sacrifice** led to independence. Kalam stresses the need for a **second national vision**—to transform India into a **developed nation**. This vision requires **integrated efforts** in agriculture, education, healthcare, technology, infrastructure, and employment generation.

The author discusses challenges such as **poverty, terrorism, communalism, natural disasters,** and **water scarcity**, proposing solutions like river networking, water conservation, and people's participation. He strongly believes that India's greatest strength lies in its **pluralistic culture,** tolerance, and moral values taught by leaders like **Mahatma Gandhi, Vallabhbhai Patel,** and **Vikram Sarabhai.**

Kalam concludes that only through **Unity of Minds,** mutual understanding, and ethical leadership can India achieve peace, prosperity, and sustainable development.

Message of the Lesson

- National progress needs **Unity of Minds and Unity of Purpose**
- **Diversity** is India's greatest strength
- Development must be **value-based and inclusive**
- Youth and leaders must act as **role models**
- Nation comes above **individual, party, or organisation**

Sudha Murty: The Woman Who Inspires Many

A writer, philanthropist and an entrepreneur, Sudha Murty is greatly admired and respected for being a prolific writer and being one of the brains behind Infosys - one of India's leading IT companies. Soberly dressed in traditional Indian attire, she is also globally recognized for her philanthropic work - facilitating the education of poor children, passion & compassion to fight for women's rights, ability to speak her mind, simplicity, and her humility. On April 5, 2023, she received Padma Bhushan award for her immense contribution to the field of social work from India's President Draupadi Murmu. Her multifaceted personality has been a tremendous source of inspiration for me.

Early Life and Education

Born in the small town of Shiggaon in Karnataka, India, Sudha Murty had the passion to excel right from her childhood. She was born into a family that valued education and hard work. Sudha's parents encouraged her to pursue her dreams even when the odds were against her. Sudha Murty earned her B.E. in Electrical and Electronics Engineering from the B.V.B. College of Engineering & Technology in Hubli (presently known as KLE Technological University), which she followed with an M.E. in Computer Science from the globally renowned Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore, in 1974. An excellent student, she was a top student in both her bachelor's and master's degrees.

Brilliant Penmanship

Sudha Murty is also a prolific author who has published over ninety-five titles in sixteen Indian languages. She has received many awards at the state, national, and international levels, including the Rajyaprashasti, and six doctorates from universities across India. Her books focus on a variety of societal and civic issues while also entertaining and educating the masses and the children. Her books are known for their simplicity, humor, and ability to connect with readers of all ages. She is India's highest-selling female author. She has been a role model to many writers and women around the world.

Fearless and Confident

Sudha's passion for learning and her curious nature led her to study engineering at B.V.B. College of Engineering and Technology in Hubli. It is simply incredible to note that she was the only female student at her engineering college in Hubli. Her male classmates weren't derisive, but they certainly didn't conceal their amusement at having a girl in their carpentry workshop. "I never missed a single class because I knew if I did no one would help me. It made me self-sufficient. It also made me talk to boys on equal terms," she shares. Sudha was accepted to the college by the principal with the three utterly illogical requirements of always wearing a saree there, never eating in the canteen, and never engaging in conversation with male students. A woman's journey towards pursuing her dreams and ambitions consists of several bumps of societal bias. There have been several sectors that had their gates open for 'Men only'. She is known for her feisty letter to JRD Tata in reaction to a TELCO (now Tata Motors) job notice inviting applications for trainee engineers, where women were asked not to apply. She was subsequently hired as their first female engineer. It was there that she met her future husband, Narayana Murty, who would later become her partner in life and philanthropy. Sudha's hard work and dedication soon paid off, and she was promoted to the position of Senior Systems Analyst. Despite her success in the corporate world, she felt that something was missing in her life.

Sudha Murty has worked tirelessly to be a strong voice in educating people on the need to overcome gender inequality in all aspects of life. Her work is an inspiration for all who strive to achieve gender parity and combat sexism. She is

portrayed as a lady who is opposed to any kind of discrimination against women. She has no qualms in showing this to anyone regardless of age or designation. In her book, *Women@Work*, she discusses the challenges that women face in the workplace and how they can rise to the occasion by taking charge of their careers and manage their time effectively. A woman who refused to stay on the sidelines because of the large gender bias of the country, Sudha is an icon to the youth of today.

Genuine and Humble

Sudha Murty is easily one of the richest women in the country but is far from flaunting her wealth to the masses. One of her key aspects is the simple values that she adheres to in a world that emphasizes materialism. She sure knows the art of simplicity, and being a genuine human being is something she does flawlessly! "No jewelry or new saris for me... I have everything I need," says Murty. Three days in a year she goes to the Raghavendra Swamy temple in Jayanagar. She cleans the kitchen and the adjoining rooms; washes the dirty utensils, dusts the shelves, chops vegetables, takes inventory of stock, sweeps the yard, and empties the trash cans. Influenced by the Sikh philosophy of Kar Seva, Sudha believes that it is easy to give money but devoting yourself to physical seva is not. She further added that we are all equal in the eye of God but not in the eyes of society. Her legacy will continue to inspire generations to come, reminding us all that one person can make a difference in the world. "If you really understand life, power and money should not affect you. But you require a strong mind for that. Don't be carried away with power, with money. Enjoy the small things and work hard and with honesty. It may not pay you immediately, but in the longer run you can create something good," she said. Simple living and high thinking are her philosophies that continue to inspire people all around the globe.

Gives Back to Society

One of the best things that we as human beings can do is care for the underprivileged. Sudha Murty stands by the belief that money always changes hands and that giving back to society fosters significant goodwill. Her noble beliefs are reflected in her active participation in social work for art and culture, public hygiene, healthcare, poverty alleviation, and women empowerment and education. In 1996, she founded Infosys Foundation, the philanthropic arm of Infosys Technologies. Through the foundation, Sudha focused on healthcare, education, and rural development. She worked tirelessly to build schools, hospitals, and community centers across India, helping to improve the lives of countless people in underprivileged communities. One of Sudha Murty's defining moments in her life was when 3,000 rehabilitated sex workers arranged a thanksgiving ceremony for her after 18 years of tirelessly working with them to empower them to lead a normal life. She said, "I went there on the stage and the 3,000 of them, who were now leading normal lives, wanted to hear from me and I was absolutely speechless. The tears started to flow, and I quoted a shloka from Ramayana: 'God... don't make me rich, don't make me beautiful, don't make me a queen. If at all you want to give me anything, give me a soft heart and a strong hand, so I can wipe the tears of others.' At that moment, I realized why I was born, and it gave me a tremendous amount of peace." A tremendously inspirational moment! Sudha's work with the Infosys Foundation earned her many accolades and awards, including the Padma Shri, one of India's highest civilian honors. Sudha Murty is an undeniable source of motivation for many in the Indian literary scene. Her life story is a testament to the power of hard work, dedication, and a willingness to help others. From her incredible achievements to her charitable works, she has demonstrated that true success comes from adding value and making a difference to the lives of others. Sudha is a terrific example of how anyone can make it big if they put their mind to it, no matter where they come from or what challenges life throws at them. We should learn from her exemplary life and strive to be like her in order to create positive change around us.

--Reena Shah

About the Lesson

- **Genre:** Biographical Essay / Inspirational Prose / Indian English Prose
- **Subject:** Life and achievements of **Sudha Murty**
- **Style:** Simple, narrative, reflective, inspirational
- **Tone:** Respectful, motivational, appreciative
- **Theme:** Women empowerment, simplicity, social service, education, compassion, perseverance, moral values

About the Author: Reena Shah

- **Full Name:** Reena Shah
- **Nationality:** Indian
- **Profession:** Writer, Essayist, Educator
- **Known for:** Writing inspiring biographies and essays highlighting moral values and social contributions
- **Language:** English
- **Major Contributions:** Documenting lives of notable personalities, promoting social awareness and motivation through literature

About the Author: Sudha Murty (1950–)

- **Full Name:** Sudha Murty
- **Nationality:** Indian
- **Profession:** Writer, Philanthropist, Social Worker, Entrepreneur
- **Known for:** Prolific author, Infosys Foundation, promoting education and women empowerment
- **Language:** English (and multiple Indian languages)
- **Major Contributions:** Literature, social work, rural development, education, healthcare, philanthropy
- **Awards:** Padma Bhushan (2023), Padma Shri

Summary / Central Idea

The essay highlights the life, achievements, and inspiring qualities of **Sudha Murty**, a **writer, philanthropist, and entrepreneur**. Born in **Shiggaon, Karnataka**, she excelled academically, becoming the only female student in her engineering college and later one of **India's first female engineers at TELCO**.

Sudha Murty is admired for her **courage, confidence, and determination** to overcome **gender bias** and societal barriers. She balances professional success with **simplicity, humility, and ethical values**. Her work with the **Infosys Foundation** reflects her commitment to **education, healthcare, women empowerment, and rural development**.

Through her actions and character, Sudha Murty inspires people to **work hard, stay humble, and serve society**, demonstrating that true success comes from **helping others and making a positive difference**.

Central Idea: The essay conveys that **courage, compassion, simplicity, and dedication to social service** are the true measures of an inspiring life, and Sudha Murty is a role model for overcoming challenges while contributing meaningfully to society.

Message of the Lesson

- **Courage and determination** can help overcome societal and gender barriers.
- **Simplicity, humility, and ethical values** are as important as professional success.
- **Education, hard work, and perseverance** lead to personal growth and achievement.
- **Serving society and helping the underprivileged** brings true fulfillment.
- **Role models like Sudha Murty** inspire others to pursue excellence and contribute to the welfare of humanity.